

Carry souls across the river. Keep the lantern burning.

The Ferryman is a solo survival card game in which the player becomes Charon's apprentice. Guide souls to the destinations they seek, use the memories they leave behind, and survive each return to the shore.

A RIVER OF DEATH AND REMEMBRANCE

The theme connects death, memory and responsibility. Souls wait at the shore with different destinations, while fog drains the Light needed to continue the journey. Souls left waiting or kept aboard too long grow angry and become wraiths. Deliveries can leave memories that help with a later crossing.

The dark river, underworld destinations and lantern imagery give these decisions a somber setting. The design aims to make caring for passengers and keeping the journey alive feel closely connected.

THE CORE IDEA

Each trip begins by choosing passengers within the boat's limited capacity. At every fork, choose a destination from the offered pair. The useful route depends on who is aboard, how much Light remains, how angry the passengers are, and which memories are available.

Memories can restore Light, reveal upcoming routes, reduce anger or protect against danger. PoLong arrivals add pressure during the journey. Once the boat is empty, returning restores some Light, but the souls left on shore must first survive their own anger check.

A PERSONAL STORY WITHIN THE JOURNEY

The optional Mother and Child quest asks the player to deliver Child to Haven before Mother reaches Tartarus. Completing this sequence grants Passage, a special memory that can deliver a passenger instantly. It gives the route decisions a continuing family story across trips.

DESIGN FOCUS

A repeating survival journey built around passenger choice, uncertain routes and the timing of memories. Play continues until Light reaches zero or the player chooses to stop.

THE FERRYMAN

HOW TO PLAY | PAPER GAME

vo.6

Goal: Keep the lantern alive through repeated trips. At 0 **Light**, lose immediately, before any delivery, reward or recovery. There is no fixed victory or final cycle.

1. SET UP

Start with 6 **Light** (maximum 6), 4 **ordinary seats**, no memories and all anger at 0. Set the outward-round counter to 0 and cycle to 1. Place Mother, Child, Merchant, Mason and Cook on the shore; shuffle Soldier, Poet and Keeper into the arrival pile. A facilitator supplies pairs of destination offers, concealing unrevealed future pairs.

2. BOARD AT THE SHORE

Take at least one ordinary soul within 4 seats. Soldier uses 2 seats; other ordinary souls use 1. Reset boarded souls' Ship Anger to 0. Boarding choices can change until departure.

3. REPEAT EACH OUTWARD ROUND

Memory: Optionally play one memory and resolve its card. If Passage empties the boat, return immediately without starting a round.

PoLong: Advance the global round. Every third outward round, add a fresh PoLong at anger 0. It uses no seat. Keep counting across trips.

Travel: Choose one of the two offered destinations. Add base fog and +1 fog for each PoLong at anger 2 or 3. Apply any played protection and pay the remaining fog in Light, minimum 0.

Deliver: Optionally deliver passengers whose preferred destination matches. Take their printed memory rewards. Child and PoLong give none; deliveries do not directly restore Light. Put delivered ordinary souls in the resolved discard.

Anger: Every passenger still aboard gains 1 Ship Anger. At 4, it becomes a wraith: lose 1 Light, then remove it. Apply any remaining Guard protection. Removed ordinary souls enter the resolved discard; PoLong returns to supply. Discard excess memories to keep at most 3. Repeat until the boat is empty.

4. RETURN AND CONTINUE

Return costs no travel fog and does not advance the round. Optionally play one memory, unless Passage already spent this return's allowance. Waiting souls gain 1 Shore Anger; at 2, each becomes a wraith, costs 1 Light and enters the resolved discard. Apply played Guard protection. If alive, recover 2 Light (maximum 6), record the cycle and refill the shore to 5. When arrivals run out, shuffle only resolved ordinary souls. New arrivals start at anger 0. Begin the next trip with new offers.

MEMORIES & THE OPTIONAL QUEST

Play at most **one memory before each outward round or return**; unused cards carry over. Used and discarded memories return to their reserve. Deliver Child to Haven before Mother to Tartarus to gain Passage alongside Mother's normal reward, once per run. Mother first, or losing a still-required family member, fails the quest. Follow the memory cards for exact effects.